

separatism had gained a strong following. Bartók was part of a generation inspired by the optimism of the political activist Ferenc Kossuth and his Party of Independence. His orchestral tone poem *Kossuth* (1903) paid tribute to Ferenc's father, the reformer and national hero Lajos Kossuth. Bartók had already written prolifically for piano and chamber ensembles, but it was this work—much influenced by Richard Strauss's tone poems—that truly put him on the map. After this, his musical language developed considerably under the new influence of Debussy, whose “great service to music,” according to Bartók, “was to reawaken among all musicians an awareness of harmony and its possibilities.”

Around 1904, Bartók and Kodály acquired an Edison phonograph and set out into the remoter corners of the Hungarian countryside to record and catalog the folk songs that they heard there. From this time on, Bartók began to adapt traditional Hungarian songs into works for the concert hall: examples include the *Six Romanian Folk Dances*, the *Violin Duos*, and various sets of folk songs with piano accompaniment. Folk music had a significant impact on his language—through its rhythms and harmonies and the use of quarter-tones—and is evident in all areas of his work, from string quartets to orchestral and operatic pieces. He once wrote enthusiastically, “Another completely different factor makes contemporary (20th-century) music realistic: that, half consciously, half intentionally, it searches for impressions from that great reality of folk art, which encompasses everything.”